

The Forge

Field Manual — game systems & rules · v0.2

A festival-scale, real-world strategy game · design sample for SEED · Aliaskar Bekishev · alyasska.github.io ·
github.com/Alyasska/seed-artifact

Hundreds of players, two-to-four factions, one outdoor field, a single **90-minute session**. Capture-the-Flag crossed with a real-time strategy game, run by a costumed Game Master with NFC totems, an app, and LED towers for an interface. You take ground by standing on it and tapping it — **there are no eliminations**. Every attendee plays the full ninety minutes. This manual is the ruleset the balance sandbox tunes; the numbers below are its defaults (control resolves per 10-second tick; the economy ticks once a minute).

The Field

The field is a graph of **sectors**, each a physical control point (an NFC totem). Natural features — a creek, a ridge, the reservoir — split it into **bridge-gated** halves:

those crossings are impassable until an Engineer builds a bridge. On a real venue (Lake San Antonio, a Lightning-in-a-Bottle site) the sectors snap to dry ground and the water becomes the ravine.

Control & Capture

Each sector carries a **control meter** from -100 (one faction) to $+100$ (the other). Standing on a sector adds **presence**; net presence drives the meter, capped so a single deathball can't steamroll. The meter flips ownership at ± 60 (hysteresis), and uncontested ground slowly drifts back to neutral — you cannot hold the whole map passively.

Rule · Presence by Pulse

Presence = *distinct* bodies tapped in the last 60 s (re-tap to hold). Net pressure = (attackers – defenders) $\times$ class weight $\times$ **capRate 6**, capped at ± 5 . A ~ 3 -net edge takes a neutral sector in about a minute. Holding is an active job — patrol, don't camp.

Player Classes

A faction's composition is a deck-building choice — too many Anchors can't take ground; too many Runners can't hold it. Presence weight is read on attack / on defense.

RUNNER

scout · intel

Presence 0.5 atk / 0.5 def · **Move** fast ($\times 1.6$)

Reveals fog for HQ; carries intel chits at double speed; can plant a feint.

ANCHOR

hold ground

Presence 1.0 atk / **2.0 def** · **Move** slow ($\times 0.6$)

Dig In: +50% defensive control on the held sector. The wall a faction is built around.

ENGINEER

bridges

Presence 1.0 / 1.0 · **Move** normal

Builds a bridge at a gate (kit + 120 Supply); can sabotage one enemy bridge for 3 min.

QUARTERMASTER
+50% yield

Presence 1.0 / 1.0 · **Move** normal
+50% Supply on the sector they occupy; carries double supply tokens.

HERALD
rally · parley

Presence 1.0 / 1.0 · **Move** normal
Opens a parley channel between HQs; Rally grants allies +1 presence here for 60 s.

The Economy

Held sectors pay **Supply** into one faction pool. A per-sector yield cap means stacking is wasted — spread out. The trailing faction captures harder (rubber-band), the brake on snowball.

Source / Sink	Value
Sector held	+10 Supply / min

Stronghold held	+30 / min (×3)
Quartermaster present	+50% that sector
Build a bridge	120 Supply
Recon report / Comms jam	20 / 80
Battering a Wall	10 Supply → −1 Wall

Bridges · Intel · Siege

Bridges open a gate over the ravine and are *shared* — your attack route is also your exposure. **Intel** is a resource: the HQ map is fogged, Runners scout, recon reports and comms-jams buy or deny information; a

faction can win blind by out-scouting. **Siege** is the endgame: a stronghold's **Wall (100)** is invulnerable until the Siege phase, then falls only to bodies + a Supply dump (battering) after the attacker holds the **delay tower** for 3 continuous minutes.

The 90-Minute Arc

Time	Phase	Unlocks
0–15	Muster & landgrab	strongholds safe; grab neutrals
15–45	Contact	bridges buildable; intel war
45–70	Escalation	comms-jam + parley; leader ganked

70–90	Siege	bell rings; Walls batterable; delay towers
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The GM paces the phases and injects events (a supply drop, a storm that closes a region), sells intel, and adjudicates parley — the live balance valve the sandbox tells you where to set.

Balance Levers — the Honesty Ledger

Ten dials tune the game. Each states what it buys and what it costs.

Capture rate

intent make taking a sector a ~minute push. **trade** fast churns the map, slow lets first-movers lock it. **fails** too fast → flicker; too slow → stalemate.

Comeback aid

intent keep the last 30 minutes alive for the trailing side. **trade** fights snowball but softens the reward for early play. **fails** too high → the lead is meaningless.

Battering rate

intent make the siege endgame reachable — bodies and Supply. **trade** fast is decisive, slow makes sieges rare. **fails** too slow → sieges never finish.

What the Sandbox Found

- **Self-play found an exploit** the four heuristics didn't (~100% vs the pool) — a better playtester.
- **Terrain flips balance:** the same ruleset goes aggressor-dominant (~75%) on real Lake San Antonio. Balance is per-venue.
- **Pure turtling is non-viable** (it can't cross the ravine) — a design call, with the levers to change it.

End vision. The pre-flight for The Forge: tune economy, class weights, and phase timings per venue in sim → ship a near-balanced rulebook → spend the few expensive on-field pilots validating how real humans behave. **Live demo:** alyasska.github.io/seed-artifact · **Code & full docs:** github.com/Alyasska/seed-artifact